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[GS I - GEOGRAPHY | GS III - ENVIRONMENT AND DISASTER MANAGEMENT] | **Publication Date: 27/08/2026**

Kailash Manasarovar Yatra - Disaster



> *The Kailash–Mansarovar disaster highlights the extreme vulnerability of the fragile Himalayan region to flash floods, landslides and climate-related hazards, stressing the need for early warning and resilient infrastructure.*

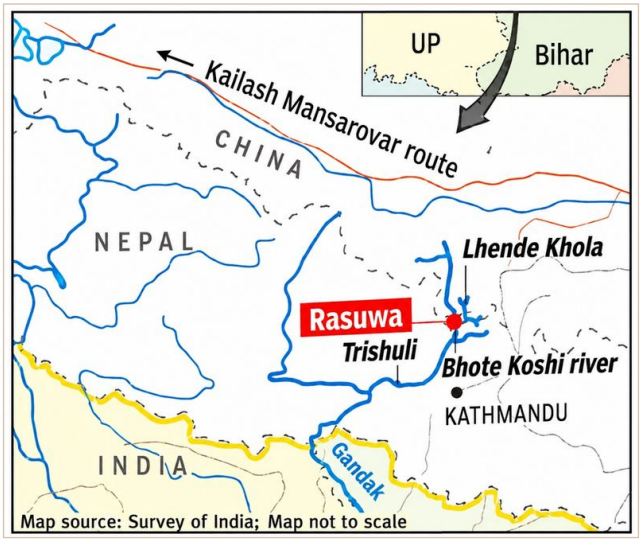
Kailash Manasarovar Yatra - Disaster

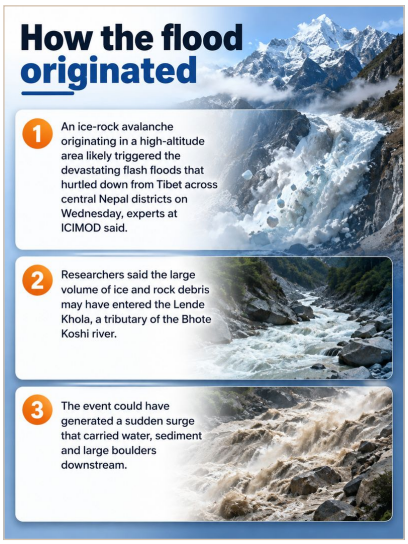
Syllabus Areas:

GS I - Geography

GS III - Environment and Disaster Management

On 26 August 2026, an unprecedented flash flood and mudslide struck the Nepal–Tibet border, sending water levels surging nearly 30 feet and killing at least 160 people. The disaster tore through the Bhote Koshi and Trishuli river valleys, sweeping away settlements, hydropower infrastructure and parts of the pilgrim route, while hundreds remained missing, including scores of Kailash Mansarovar pilgrims from India.







What are Flash Floods?

Flash floods are sudden, high-velocity floods caused by intense rainfall, rapid snow or glacier melt, landslides, or dam failure, leaving little warning and causing severe destruction in vulnerable areas.

What is Cloudburst?

A sudden, highly localized, intense rainfall event, typically exceeding **100 mm in a short period**, causing flash floods, landslides, debris flows, and severe damage.

What is a Glacier?

A large, slow-moving mass of compacted snow and ice formed over years, flowing under gravity and shaping landscapes while storing freshwater and responding to climate change.

What is an Avalanche?

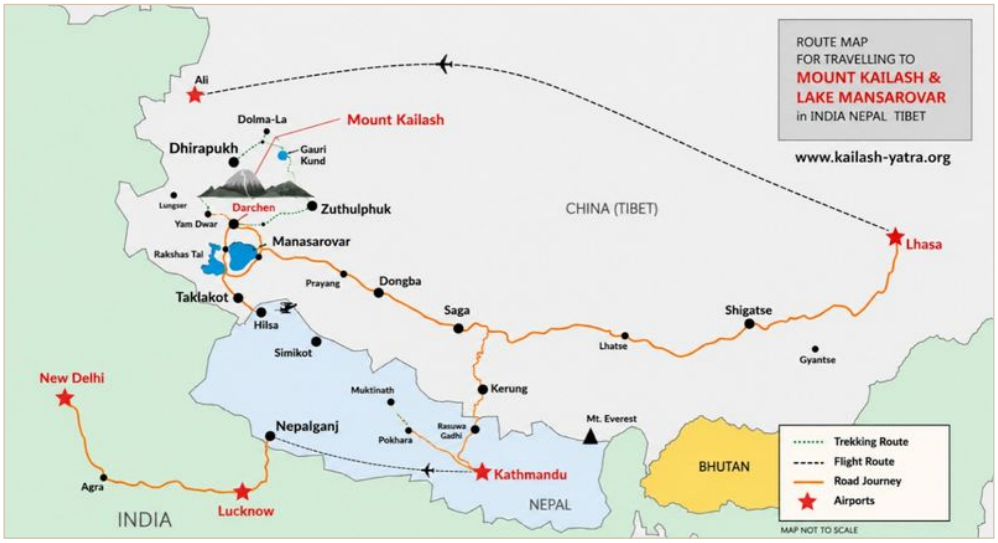
A rapid downward movement of snow, ice, rocks, and debris along a mountain slope, triggered by gravity, heavy snowfall, earthquakes, warming, or unstable terrain.

What is Western Disturbance?

Extratropical weather systems originating near the Mediterranean region, bringing winter rainfall and snowfall to northwest India, Pakistan and the Himalayas, influencing agriculture and water availability.

Topography of the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra

The pilgrimage takes place across the **high-altitude Himalayan–Tibetan landscape**, characterized by enormous elevation differences, steep mountain slopes, deep valleys, glaciers, high passes and extensive areas of permafrost.



- **High-altitude terrain:** Mount Kailash (6,638 m) and Lake Mansarovar ("H4,590 m) lie in an extreme high-altitude environment with thin air, cold temperatures and sparse vegetation.
- **Rugged Himalayan relief:** The route passes through steep slopes, narrow valleys and deep gorges, making the terrain highly susceptible to landslides and erosion.
- **High mountain passes:** Routes involve high passes such as **Lipulekh Pass ("H5,000 m)**, which face snowstorms, avalanches and rapid weather changes.
- **Glaciers and snowfields:** The Trans-Himalayan landscape contains glaciers, permanent snow and frozen ground, contributing to geomorphological instability.
- **River valleys and gorges:** Rivers such as the **Bhote Koshi and Trishuli** flow through steep-gradient valleys, allowing floods, landslides and debris flows to become rapidly destructive.

Plate Tectonics & Geographical Activity

- **Active plate collision:** The region lies where the **Indian Plate collides with the Eurasian Plate**, making the Himalayas tectonically active.
- **Continuous movement:** The Indian Plate moves northward by about **40–50 mm/year**, continuously deforming the Himalayan crust.
- **Ongoing uplift:** The Himalayas are still rising by **a few millimetres each year**, making them one of the world's most dynamic mountain systems.
- **Active faults:** Major structures such as the **Main Himalayan Thrust (MHT), Main Central Thrust (MCT), Main Boundary Thrust (MBT) and Main Frontal Thrust (MFT)** accommodate this deformation.
- **High earthquake risk:** Continuous plate convergence builds enormous stress, making the Himalayan region highly **earthquake-prone**.
- **Young & fragile mountains:** The Himalayas are geologically young, with **fractured rocks and unstable slopes**, increasing susceptibility to landslides.
- **Extreme elevation: Mount Kailash (6,638 m)** and **Lake Mansarovar ("H4,590 m)** illustrate the region's extreme altitude and relief.
- **Steep river valleys:** Rivers descend rapidly through narrow valleys, giving them strong **erosive and flood-producing potential**.
- **Multiple hazards interact: Tectonic activity, steep slopes, rainfall, glaciers, snowmelt and river erosion** can combine to trigger landslides, debris flows, avalanches and flash floods.



Mythological History of Kailash–Mansarovar

Kailash Mountain in Ancient Sanskrit Literature

Mount Kailash (‘Yhf]>“¸• highly sacred place in ancient Sanskrit literature:

- **Vedas:** References to Kailash are limited; its later prominence is more evident in the epics and Puranas.
- **Ramayana:** Kailash is described as a magnificent Himalayan mountain associated with **Lord Shiva** and his divine abode.
- **Mahabharata:** Kailash appears as a sacred Himalayan region connected with **Shiva, Kubera, and other divine beings**.
- **Puranas:** Texts such as the **Shiva Purana, Skanda Purana and Vishnu Purana** extensively portray Kailash as **Shiva's abode**, surrounded by divine landscapes.
- **Kalidasa:** In *Kumarasambhava*, the Himalayan world is portrayed as the majestic realm associated with **Shiva and Parvati**.
- **Religious symbolism:** Kailash represents **spiritual transcendence, asceticism, purity and the cosmic presence of Shiva**.

Ancient Sanskrit tradition transformed Kailash from a Himalayan peak into a **sacred cosmic mountain — the abode of Lord Shiva and a symbol of divine consciousness**.

- **Abode of Lord Shiva:** In **Hindu tradition**, Mount Kailash is regarded as the sacred abode of **Lord Shiva and Goddess Parvati**. Shiva is believed to reside and meditate on the mountain.
- **Mount Meru connection:** Kailash is often associated with **Mount Meru**, the cosmic mountain described in Hindu, Buddhist and Jain cosmological traditions as the centre of the universe.
- **Lake Mansarovar:** According to Hindu tradition, the lake was created by **Lord Brahma through his mind**. The name *Manas-sarovar* is derived from *manas* (mind) and *sarovar* (lake), giving it the meaning **“lake of the mind.”**
- **Source-region of sacred rivers:** The broader Kailash region is traditionally associated with the sources of four major Asian rivers: **Indus, Sutlej, Brahmaputra (Yarlung Tsangpo) and Karnali**, a major tributary of the Ganga.
- **Buddhism:** In **Tibetan Buddhism**, Mount Kailash is known as **Kang Rinpoche (“Precious Snow Jewel”)** and is associated with **Demchok (Chakrasamvara)**, representing supreme bliss and enlightenment.
- **Jainism:** Jain tradition associates Mount Kailash, particularly **Ashtapada**, with **Rishabhanatha (Adinath)**, the first Tirthankara, who is believed to have attained liberation there.
- **Bon tradition:** In the indigenous **Tibetan Bon** tradition, Mount Kailash is a sacred mountain associated with **Zhang Zhung** cosmology and the deity **Tönpa Shenrab**.
- **Sacred circumambulation:** Pilgrims traditionally perform **kora/parikrama** around Mount Kailash. The circuit is considered spiritually significant, with different traditions attaching different religious meanings to completing it.

Travel route to reach the Kailash–Manasarovar region

The Government of India currently organizes the **Kailash Manasarovar Yatra through two routes**: **Lipulekh Pass (Uttarakhand)** and **Nathu La Pass (Sikkim)**. In 2026, the official durations are approximately **22 days via Lipulekh** and **21 days via Nathu La**.



1. Lipulekh Pass Route — Uttarakhand

New Delhi !' Tanakpur !' Dharchula !' Gunji !' Kalapani !' Nabhidhang !' Lipulekh Pass !' Purang/Taklakot !' Manasarovar !' Darchen !' Kailash Parikrama

The 2026 itinerary records the Indian-side journey through **Tanakpur, Dharchula, Gunji, Kalapani and Nabhidhang**, followed by crossing **Lipulekh Pass ("H5,050 m)** into the Tibet region.

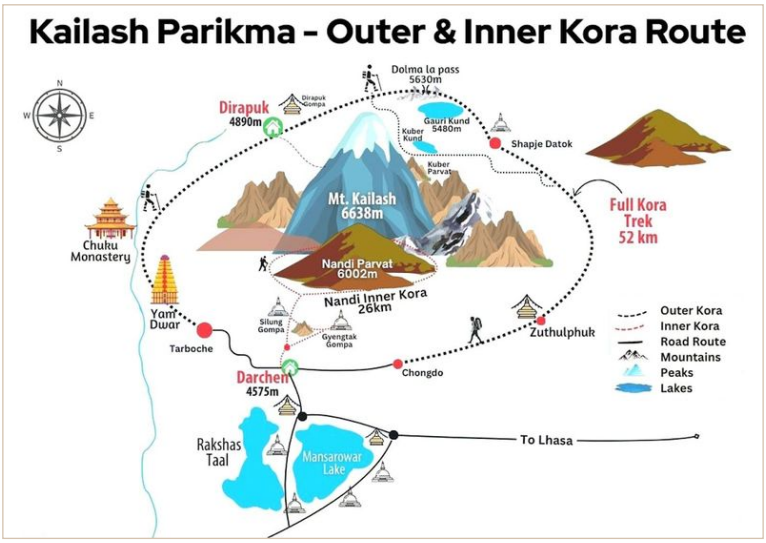
Key point: This is the more trekking-intensive route. The official FAQ estimates roughly **200 km of trekking** over the entire Lipulekh pilgrimage.

2. Nathu La Route — Sikkim

New Delhi !' Bagdogra !' Gangtok !' Nathu La !' Tibet !' Shigatse/Saga region !' Manasarovar !' Darchen !' Kailash Parikrama

Nathu La is largely **motorable**, making this route considerably less trekking-intensive. The official FAQ estimates approximately **35–40 km of trekking**, primarily for the Kailash Parikrama.

Mount Kailash Parikrama / Kora



The **Parikrama** is the circumambulation of Mount Kailash.

Darchen !’ Yam Dwar !’ Dirapuk !’ Dolma La Pass !’ Zuthulphuk !’ Darchen

The official 2026 itinerary identifies:

- **Darchen** – base for the Kailash Parikrama
- **Yam Dwar** – starting point
- **Dirapuk** – first major halt
- **Dolma La** – highest point, about **5,590 m**
- **Zuthulphuk** – second major halt
- **Darchen** – completion of the circuit

Manasarovar Parikrama

A separate circumambulation is undertaken around **Lake Manasarovar**. The official itinerary places **Manasarovar Parikrama after completion of the Kailash Parikrama**.

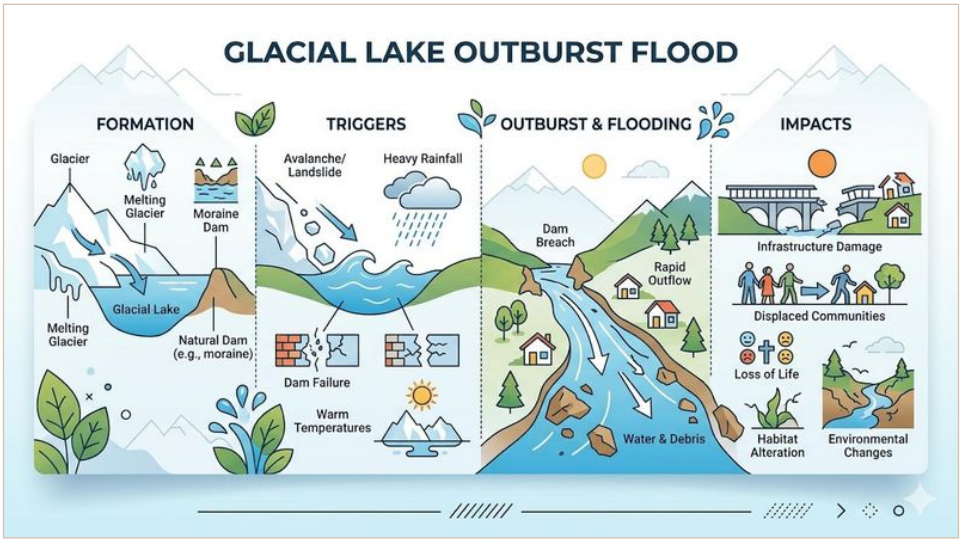
UPSC angle: The map can effectively illustrate the intersection of **Himalayan geography + pilgrimage tourism + transboundary rivers + India–China relations + disaster vulnerability + climate change**. The recent resumption of the Yatra also makes it a useful contemporary example

Major Disasters in the Kailash–Mansarovar Region & Himalayan Corridor

- **1998 – Malpa Landslide, Uttarakhand:** A massive landslide buried Malpa village, killing around **221 people**, including about **60 Kailash Mansarovar pilgrims**.
- **2013 – Kedarnath Disaster, Uttarakhand:** Extreme rainfall and flash floods triggered widespread **flooding and landslides**, causing thousands of deaths and extensive destruction.
- **2021 – Chamoli Flash Flood, Uttarakhand:** A **rock–ice avalanche** triggered a devastating flash flood, killing or leaving missing more than **200 people** and damaging hydropower projects.
- **2023 – South Lhonak GLOF, Sikkim:** A **Glacial Lake Outburst Flood** caused severe flooding, killing around **179 people** and damaging major infrastructure.
- **2025 – Rasuwagadhi Flood, Nepal–Tibet Border:** A sudden **glacial/supraglacial lake outburst** caused a flash flood that killed at least **9 people**, with others missing, and destroyed the Friendship Bridge and infrastructure.
- **2026 – Nepal–Tibet Border Disaster:** A massive **glacial collapse, landslide/debris flow and flash flood** devastated the Rasuwagadhi–Bhote Koshi corridor, killing **160+ people** and leaving hundreds missing, including **Kailash Mansarovar pilgrims**.

What is a Glacial Lake Outburst Flood (GLOF)?

A **Glacial Lake Outburst Flood (GLOF)** is a **sudden and often catastrophic release of water from a lake formed by glacial meltwater**, causing a powerful flood downstream.



The Kailash–Mansarovar tragedy highlights Himalayan vulnerability to climate and geological hazards, underscoring the need for **early warnings, resilient infrastructure, sustainable pilgrimage management, environmental protection**

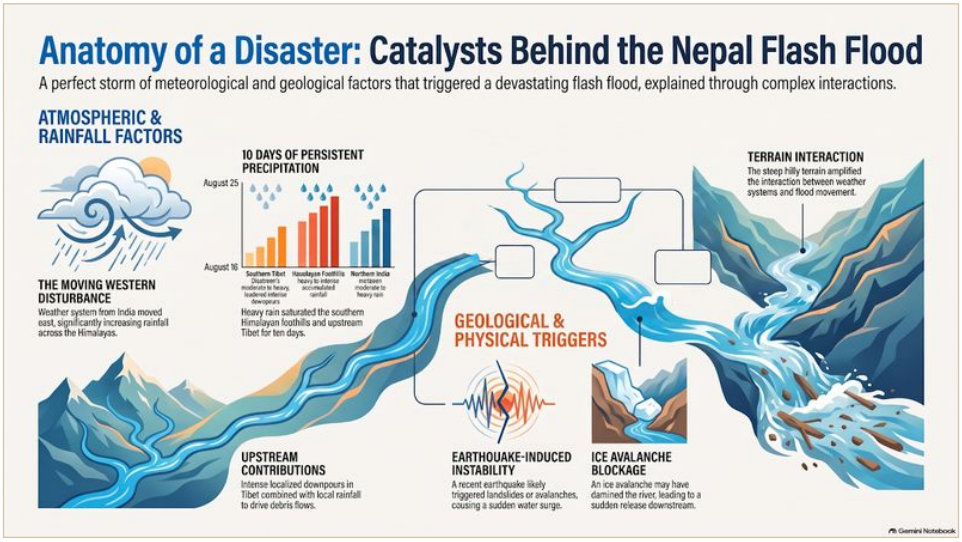
and transboundary disaster cooperation.

Western disturbance linked to Nepal flood

A western disturbance that brought rain to parts of northern India, and subsequently moved eastwards towards the Himalayas, may have contributed to the weather conditions preceding the devastating flash flood in Nepal on Wednesday, according to a senior India Meteorological Department official.

The same western disturbance system was moving eastwards, bringing increased rainfall activity towards the Himalayan region.

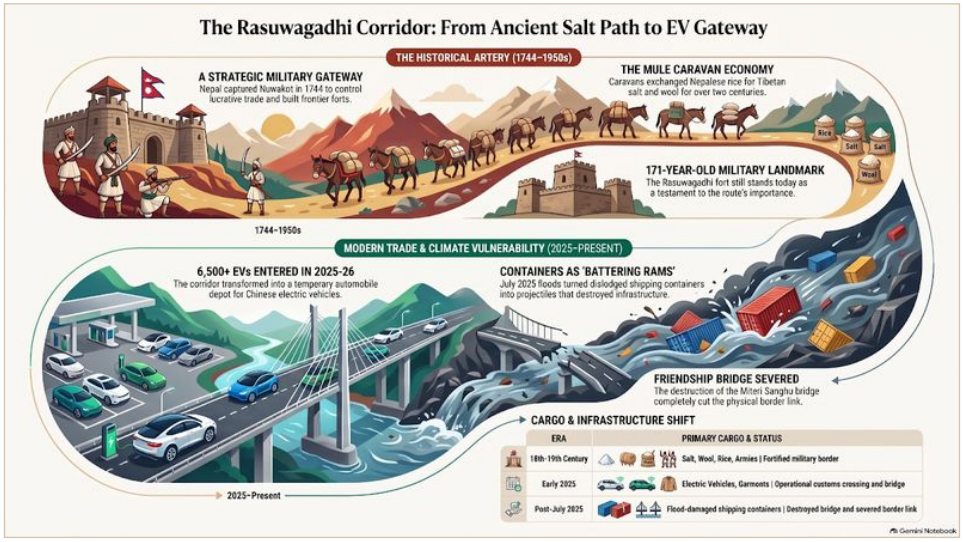
The western disturbance should be understood as a possible contributor to the broader rainfall environment rather than as an established direct cause of the flash flood. The immediate mechanism behind the sudden release of water remains under investigation.



For centuries, flood-hit corridor was key route of Himalayan trade



The Himalayan corridor, particularly Rasuwagadhi, devastated by the flash flood had served for more than 260 years as one of Nepal's key trans-Himalayan arteries, carrying traders, pilgrims and armies before becoming a major gateway for Chinese electronics, garments, footwear and electric vehicles entering the country.


The Rasuwagadhi Corridor: From Ancient Salt Path to EV Gateway
THE HISTORICAL ARTERY (1744–1950s)
A STRATEGIC MILITARY GATEWAY
Nepal captured Nuwakot in 1744 to control lucrative trade and built frontier forts.
THE MULE CARAVAN ECONOMY
Caravans exchanged Nepalese rice for Tibetan salt and wool for over two centuries.
Rice
Salt
Salt
Wool
171-YEAR-OLD MILITARY LANDMARK
The Rasuwagadhi fort still stands today as a testament to the route's importance.
1744–1950s
MODERN TRADE & CLIMATE VULNERABILITY (2025–PRESENT)
6,500+ EVs ENTERED IN 2025-26
The corridor transformed into a temporary automobile depot for Chinese electric vehicles.
CONTAINERS AS 'BATTERING RAMS'
July 2025 floods turned dislodged shipping containers into projectiles that destroyed infrastructure.
FRIENDSHIP BRIDGE SEVERED
The destruction of the Miteri Sanghu bridge completely cut the physical border link.
2025–Present
CARGO & INFRASTRUCTURE SHIFT
ERA
PRIMARY CARGO & STATUS
18th-19th Century
Salt, Wool, Rice, Armies | Fortified military border
Early 2025
Electric Vehicles, Garments | Operational customs crossing and bridge
Post-July 2025
Flood-damaged shipping containers | Destroyed bridge and severed border link
Gemini Notebook